

choice is that it allows older or underpowered PCs to take advantage of the latest and greatest software. As DE's like XFCE and LXDE are tailored to be light on system resources, they require a measly 512MB of RAM to run smoothly. If you'd tried Linux before and are giving it a second shot now, expect to be amazed by the offerings. This particular space has undergone exceptional changes in the last 3-4 years, with developers aiming for a unified computing experience across different screen sizes.

1. GNOME

The GNOME project is one of the largest contributors in the Open Source world, and the GNOME desktop environment is admittedly one of the most popular ones out there. The DE actually consists of two distinct desktop interfaces (called shells). The newer GNOME Shell and the older (albeit more mature), GNOME Classic. Both use the same underlying Window Manager – Metacity – and have the same collection of utilities and applications.

GNOME Shell features a bare, touch-optimized look with larger icons, and some innovative desktop paradigms such as the Activities Overview – a way to view all of your open windows at once and access commonly used applications, system-wide search from the desktop (include Wikipedia and Google searches), and an integrated Notification Center which lets you respond to notifications from Instant Messaging or Email clients inline, without leaving your current window. Needless to say, every aspect of the interface is highly themeable, including the icons. Visit <http://dgit.in/GNOMELook> for a large selection of themes, most of which can be edited further as they just use simple CSS. One particularly neat feature of GNOME Shell is the Online Accounts feature which lets you plug your accounts like Google, Facebook, Twitter, Pocket etc. into the OS, which then pulls useful information from these accounts for you. For e.g., the feature automatically indexes your documents in Google Drive so they appear alongside your local documents when you search from the Activities menu. Similarly, photos from Facebook and Contacts from Gmail, Facebook and Twitter are automatically pulled into the GNOME Contacts app. In addition, Shell allows developers to write extensions using Javascript and CSS, which can be installed from any web browser in just one click, similar to how extensions are installed for Firefox or Chrome. No installation required!

The GNOME Classic retains the traditional desktop metaphor – sporting toolbars on the top and bottom of the screen with an application menu, a taskbar which lists all the currently open windows, and a system tray